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Showers 57/43 • Tomorrow: Partly sunny 59/42 **B18**

Democracy Dies in Darkness

SATURDAY, NOVEMBER 22, 2025 • \$4

U.S. leans on Kyiv to sign peace accord

Ukraine given Thursday deadline to accept deal or lose war support

BY SIOBHÁN O'GRADY, CATHERINE BELTON, MICHAEL BIRNBAUM AND JOHN HUDSON

KYIV — The White House is pressuring Ukraine to sign on to its new peace proposal by Thanksgiving or lose U.S. support in its war with Russia, according to five people familiar with the talks.

U.S. Army Secretary Daniel Driscoll presented Ukrainian President Volodymyr Zelensky on Thursday with a version of the 28-point plan President Donald Trump's special envoy Steve Witkoff recently drafted with Russian envoy Kirill Dmitriev.

That plan, leaked to the news media and confirmed by several officials, includes several red lines for Ukraine, including a significant reduction of its army size and ceding territory to Russia that Moscow has not conquered militarily.

Zelensky addressed Ukrainians on Friday and told them the

SEE UKRAINE ON A13

Appeal to pope: Officials seek Vatican role in Ukraine talks. **A13**

Coast Guard reverses stance on swastika, noose symbols

BY TARA COPP, MICHELLE BOORSTEIN, HARI RAJ AND VICTORIA BISSET

In a stunning and hasty reversal, the U.S. Coast Guard announced late Thursday that swastikas and nooses are prohibited hate symbols — erasing an attempt to soften their definition after the plan elicited furious backlash.

The abrupt policy change occurred hours after The Washington Post first reported that the service was about to enact new harassment guidelines that downgraded the meaning of such symbols of fascism and racism, labeling them instead “potentially divisive.” That shift had been set to take effect Dec. 15.

SEE SYMBOLS ON A2

Chinese expats have established a bustling community in the heart of West Africa. But it's now at an inflection point as Islamist militants threaten Mali.



‘Everything is possible here’

BY RACHEL CHASON WITH PHOTOGRAPHY BY CARMEN YASMINE ABD ALI IN BAMAKO, MALI

Drive through downtown in this West African capital, past traditional markets and mosques, and you arrive, unexpectedly, in a neighborhood with bubble tea shops and Chinese boutiques, where virtually every sign is in Mandarin.

In the mornings, radishes, spring onions and Chinese cabbage fly off the stalls of a husband-and-wife vegetable stand. At lunch, another couple from China prepares spicy beef stew and stir-fried snails at a restaurant across the street. As the sun sets, Chinese workers and business owners take evening strolls on the promenade that runs along the Niger River.

Chinese expats have long gravitated to this part of the Malian capital, also home to Western embassies and nonprofit headquarters, but their presence has become more visible in recent years, transforming the neighborhood into a Chinatown of sorts, according to business owners, residents and Western diplomats.

It is emblematic, experts say, of how Chinese communities in Africa exist — and often thrive — independent of the government in Beijing and state-backed enterprises. They are born of commercial desire and individual motivation, said Deborah Brautigam, director of the China-Africa Research Initiative at the Johns

SEE MALI ON A18



FROM TOP: People drive motorbikes in front of Chinese shops in Bamako. Tony Tu, seated above left, is considering returning to China after eight years, given the growing dangers. An Qun, above right, serves regulars at her tea shop.



District renters wait — and wait — in line for a shot at emergency help

BY MEAGAN FLYNN

The line snaked out the door, down the sidewalk, into the parking lot — men and women and children and the elderly, hundreds of D.C. residents who arrived at the city's family resource center for a shot at emergency rental aid.

Markisha Drake sat inside the parking garage stairwell nearby, rocking her 4-month-old bundled in a pink blanket and tiny coat inside her car seat, trying to get her to sleep. She had brought 10 diapers, a whole pack of wipes and four bottles of milk, Drake said, and at the rate the line was moving, she wasn't sure how long the bottles would last. “She's a little cranky right now,” she said, “and I get it, because she's not

used to being outside this long.”

Like the roughly 900 people who had shown up that morning, some as early as 6 a.m., Drake was behind on rent. The backlog started when she quit her job as a concierge while she was pregnant, when hyperemesis — severe, sustained nausea that hits some women during pregnancy — became unbearable, keeping her from going to work. The hole kept growing, despite subsidized rent covering two-thirds of her payments. Now she was \$7,000 behind, and there was an eviction notice on her door.

The number on the yellow ticket in her pocket was 392 — with 391 people in front of her all seeking an appointment with the D.C. Department of Human Ser-

SEE RENTERS ON A6

A mistake and a gunshot: How a house cleaner ended up dead

BY MARÍA LUISA PAÚL AND ANGIE ORELLANA HERNANDEZ

The house cleaners had circled the block in an Indiana town a few times that morning, following the mapping app's directions to the location to which they had been sent. It kept routing them back to the same gray-shingled house on Maize Lane, so María Florinda Ríos Pérez de Velásquez and her husband, Mauricio Velásquez, walked to the porch and began trying the keys, court records say.

When none of them worked — something they would normally call their boss about — they didn't even have time to reach for their phones, according to court records. Ríos Pérez de Velásquez was on the ground with a gunshot

wound to her head less than two minutes later, the records state. The homeowner, 62-year-old Curt Andersen, allegedly fired through the front door.

Boone County prosecutors charged Andersen, of Whites-town, with voluntary manslaughter Monday for a killing that started — like several other shootings in recent years — with someone approaching a stranger's home intending them no harm. Across the country, shootings linked to wrong addresses, mistaken knocks and routine doorstep interactions have intensified the debate over how far “stand your ground” protections extend in a country with historic levels of gun ownership.

Andersen's attorney, Guy Rel-

SEE SHOOTING ON A6

Trump and Mamdani, long foes, emerge from meeting as allies

BY NATALIE ALLISON

President Donald Trump and New York Mayor-elect Zohran Mamdani buried their proverbial hatchets Friday, appearing together in the Oval Office after a meeting each described as the beginning of a warm relationship — despite months of slinging insults and hammering each other's policies.

The two men with roots in Queens looked into the cameras and spoke about their shared hopes for New York, emphasized common populist ideals and pledged to work closely together, a sense of agreement that ran afoul of nearly everything their respective political bases have come to expect from them. The president even declared that he would final-

ly feel comfortable moving back to New York with the 34-year-old democratic socialist running city hall.

It was as if Trump, seated at the Resolute Desk, hadn't just called Mamdani a “communist lunatic” and a “stupid person,” and Mamdani, now standing over his right shoulder, hadn't recently referred to the president as a “despot” with a “fascist agenda.”

“I've been called much worse than a despot,” Trump explained to a reporter who asked about the recent jab, one of many questions about their past disagreements that they shrugged off. “So it's not that insulting.”

SEE MEETING ON A8

Renters vs. owners: Mamdani's proposals highlight tensions. **A7**

IN THE NEWS

The military oath's fine print Service members swear an allegiance to the Constitution, not the president, and are not required to obey “patently illegal” orders. **A2**

Texas redistricting Supreme Court Justice Samuel A. Alito Jr. lets the state's new congressional map stand, at least for now. **A5**

THE NATION Lawmakers ask the Capitol Police to investigate Trump comments aimed at them. **A4** Factories face a chronic worker shortage, a hurdle for Trump's manufacturing focus. **A5**

THE WORLD Bears in Japan have killed a record 13 people this year, prompting military action. **A9** A draft agreement at a U.N. climate change conference does not mention fossil fuels. **A10**

THE ECONOMY Consumers are still spending, retailers say, but they are looking for deals and “anxious” about making larger purchases. **A14** Facebook is testing an AI-backed personalized daily briefing for users, in a bid to compete with ChatGPT's Pulse. **A14**

STYLE Recent musicals such as “Damn Yankees” prove that sports and stage can be a winner. **B1**

SPORTS The Spirit play for the NWSL title today, and the women's soccer team has cemented a bond with the city, writes Barry Svrluga. **B7**

THE REGION Virginia opens new tolled Beltway express lanes, but a connection to the Maryland side remains in limbo. **B13** After a lifetime of championing Black history, a Maryland activist will see an apology for slavery in Anne Arundel County. **B13**

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